6.2.3 Monitoring a Lambda function with CloudWatch metrics and alarms

The Lambda function now checks the health of your website every five minutes, and a log message with the result of each health check is written to CloudWatch. But how do you get notified via email if the health check fails? Each Lambda function publishes metrics to CloudWatch by default. Table 6.2 shows important metrics. Check out http://mng.bz/m298 for a complete list of metrics.

Table 6.2 The CloudWatch metrics published by each Lambda function

Name	Description
Invocations	Counts the number of times a function is invoked. Includes successful and failed invocations.
Errors	Counts the number of times a function failed due to errors inside the function, for example, exceptions or timeouts.
Duration	Measures how long the code takes to run, from the time when the code starts executing to when it stops executing.
Throttles	As discussed at the beginning of the chapter, there is a limit for how many copies of your Lambda function can run at one time. This metric counts how many invocations have been throttled due to reaching this limit. Contact AWS support to increase the limit, if needed.

Whenever the website health check fails, the Lambda function returns an error, which increases the count of the Errors metric. You will create an alarm notifying you via email whenever this metric counts more than zero errors. In general, we recommend creating an alarm on the Errors and Throttles metrics to monitor your Lambda functions.